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The Igbo of southeast Nigeria

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Balancing Kinship Conflicts • The Mother's Agnates • The "Remote" Kinsmen

The sister's son enjoys a special status in the lineage of the mother's brother. He may not spill his blood while he is there; he may not be so provoked that he decides to bounce his buttocks on the ground, nor may he stamp a pestle on the ground. For him to do any of these is taboo, an offense to the earth-goddess. It is his *umune* who must bear the consequences of his action. While he stays with his mother's brother, he is treated with much affection and allowed a wide latitude in his behavior. His playmates are warned against the danger of making him spill his blood. He jokes at the expense of everybody, his mother's father, his mother's brother and their wives. This joking relationship is extended to all the members of the mother's brother's lineage. It is the privilege of the sister's son to take anything from his mother's brother's house without asking for permission. The fruit trees in the latter's village are at his disposal without his asking permission. When he cannot buy enough palm wine¹ to entertain his guests, he goes to his mother's brother's lineage to "poach" liquor—an expedition which earns congratulations for the most adroit poachers.

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The "Remote" Kinsmen

The father's mother's and the mother's mother's lineages constitute a person's "remote" kinsmen. They are nevertheless important in the life of a successful Igbo. The relations with one's mother's mother's agnates are more solid than those with one's father's mother's agnates. In none of these social groups, however, does the Igbo command any generally defined privileges. They assure him of support, and their members attend his feasts and title-taking

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ceremonies but they grant "poaching" privileges only to his father and his mother's brother. An Igbo who is the sister's son's son in one group or the sister's daughter's son in another group is forbidden to marry a girl directly descended from any members of these groups.

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Balancing Kinship Conflicts

It must have become apparent from this discussion that a person resolves major conflicts in his *OmOnna* by appealing for support, in the first instance, from his mother's agnates. His "second line of defense" comes from his father's mother's agnates and his mother's mother's agnates. The relation between the father and his son's mother's agnates is one of potential hostility; he owes them final bridewealth payment, which is a source of friction. By appealing to them for support against his father, the son is, in effect, resolving  68 conflict through the extension of conflict. But the father's relation with his own mother's agnates (the father's *umune*) is very friendly. They are the people who can most easily disarm him through persuasion. A son finds that it is in his own interest to appeal to all loyalties in conflicting situations. Conflict resolution between a son and a father is therefore achieved through the manipulation of these delicately balanced agnatic groups.

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¹ Another name for raphia liquor and palm liquor.

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